

WICKEDNESS UNLEASHED Director John Stefaniuk (right) with actress Rebekah Lowings

When *Wicked* first premiered more than 20 years ago, few could have predicted the scale of its global reach. With its soaring score and layered storytelling, the musical reimagined the world of Oz long before Dorothy's arrival, reframing a familiar tale through the friendship of Elphaba and Glinda. It has since become one of the most successful musicals in theatre history.

Now, more than two decades on, *Wicked* arrives at the Nita Mukesh Ambani Cultural Centre (NMACC) in Mumbai in a spectacular new production. While it retains the beloved score and script audiences all over the world know, this staging is entirely new in its direction, choreography and design. At the helm is director John Stefaniuk, whose career spans Broadway and major international productions.

For Stefaniuk, bringing a musical of this stature to a new cultural context begins with a guiding principle. "I spent many years taking care of *The Lion King* for the director," he reflects. "The number one thing I learned was that if you want audiences to feel what people felt on opening night on Broadway, you have to allow each company to speak through its own expertise and history. The more truthful it becomes, the more the audience resonates with it."

That philosophy underpins this staging. Although *Wicked* has been performed worldwide for over two decades, this is not a replica of Broadway. "This is now my vision," he says. "I want the themes and visuals to speak to people across the globe. The best way to move an audience is to find what genuinely moves you. Theatre is universal."

At its heart, *Wicked* is a story about identity, perception and the fragile line between good and wicked. In preparing his vision, Stefaniuk asked what has changed since the musical first opened. "The biggest shift has been the rise of social media," he explains. "Glinda tells her story through bubbles. To me, those bubbles feel like tweets. She becomes, in a sense, the world's first influencer. Meanwhile, Elphaba is perhaps the world's first cultural victim."

Such parallels lend immediacy to a fantastical world. "Everyone has felt at times that the world is against them," he continues. "Everyone has had to find belief within themselves to overcome that. At its core, the show has great heart. It explores two women who begin as adversaries and become profound friends. Sometimes, we only discover our true voice because someone else helps us hear it."

Wicked also remains one of the most visually ambitious musicals in contemporary theatre. With more than 100 cast, crew and orchestra members, elaborate sets and dramatic technical effects, the production is a feat of coordination. Still, scale begins simply. "A large spectacle begins in a rehearsal room with perhaps 12 people sitting around a table," Stefaniuk says. "From there, we take that honesty and place it against a larger-than-life canvas. You see a woman become a witch and fly above the audience. But it is anchored in emotional truth."

WHILE *WICKED* RETAINS **ITS BELOVED SCORE AND SCRIPT,** THIS STAGING IS ENTIRELY NEW IN ITS DIRECTION, CHOREOGRAPHY AND DESIGN

Touring adds further complexity. "These enormous sets and costumes must be packed away, transported and reassembled in a new country within days," he notes. "That requires an extraordinary design and technical team."

The recent film adaptation has reignited global interest, yet for Stefaniuk, live theatre remains singular. "Film immortalises a performance," he observes. "But live theatre is different. It surrounds you. When you enter the theatre in Mumbai, you are transported to Oz in every direction. Each performance exists only once. You are living entirely in the present moment."